Seeing the last three assassins turn invisible, Hazel shuts her eyes. Directing her clone to fan out, Hazel's clone tries to find the missing assassins as she waits near the main exit. As if guided by divine intervention, the radiant rabbits burn an invisible assassin, allowing Hazel to pinpoint their position.

"There!" The cleric shouts. "There's one behind the assassin under *Hold Person!*" Hazel casts *Produce Flame* and hurls the bolt of fire, searing the invisible attacker. Following suit, Salazar does the same, casting *Fire Bolt* and singeing the same attacker.

Wang Lei does the same. His ghost soldiers fan out and strike another invisible assassin. The spirits grabs onto the invisible man, as Wang Lei lets loose a powerful *Eldritch Blast* from his eyes and pulverize the assassin's skull, finally dropping his invisibility.

At the entrance, Thaisha bursts in through the door, slamming into Vilde and knocking her back onto the floor. "Wait wait wait! Stop! Give me the scimitars!"

Nodding quickly, the half-orc passes her weapons to her. Vilde sheathes *Dusk* under her dress as she calls out to Hazel for some mud to disguise the blade.

With no other prey, the frenzying wereboar turns around and sinks its powerful jaws in the neck of the assassin under *Hold Person*. In one forceful bite, Wukong crushes the windpipe of the assassin under the *Hold Person* spell.

The Senator Arianwen closes distance, approaching the assassin revealed by Hazel and Salazar who had been taking cover behind his friend under the *Hold Person* spell. "Who do you work for?!" She demands.

With the battle almost concluded, the group tallies up their kills. Wang Lei, Salazar and Raphael count the bodies and realize just a second too late: there is one more invisible assassin unaccounted for.

Appearing behind the Senator, singed by the Hazel's *Spirit Guardians,* is the last assassin. He leaps across the table as he drives his blade into Arianwen's back, only to withdraw it quickly to drive it in again. The Senator screams in surprise, a sound that is quickly replaced by a wet gurgling as blood begins to pour down her gown.

The assassin in front of her seizes the distraction, slashing her throat open. The Senator collapses on the ground, unconscious.

Vilde screams in horror at the sight. Watching the Senator go down, the Party bursts into action. Wang Lei fires his *Eldritch Blast*; Hazel directs her *Spirit Guardians*; Raphael casts another *Hold Person*. As the resulting deluge of powerful arcana strikes the last two surviving assassins, one is incinerated while the other is paralyzed by tentacles.

Yet it all happens almost a world away for Vilde. The rogue moves before her body even realizes. She arrives at the broken form of the elf that has nurtured her her whole life as hot tears find freedom. Cradling her dying Mummy, Vilde can only watch on as the proud Senator give a soft smile before the light leaves her eyes.

Difficult Conversations

There is a moment of stunned silence. All of you watch the Senator's body go limp. As Arianwen succumbs to her wounds, what is Vilde feeling?

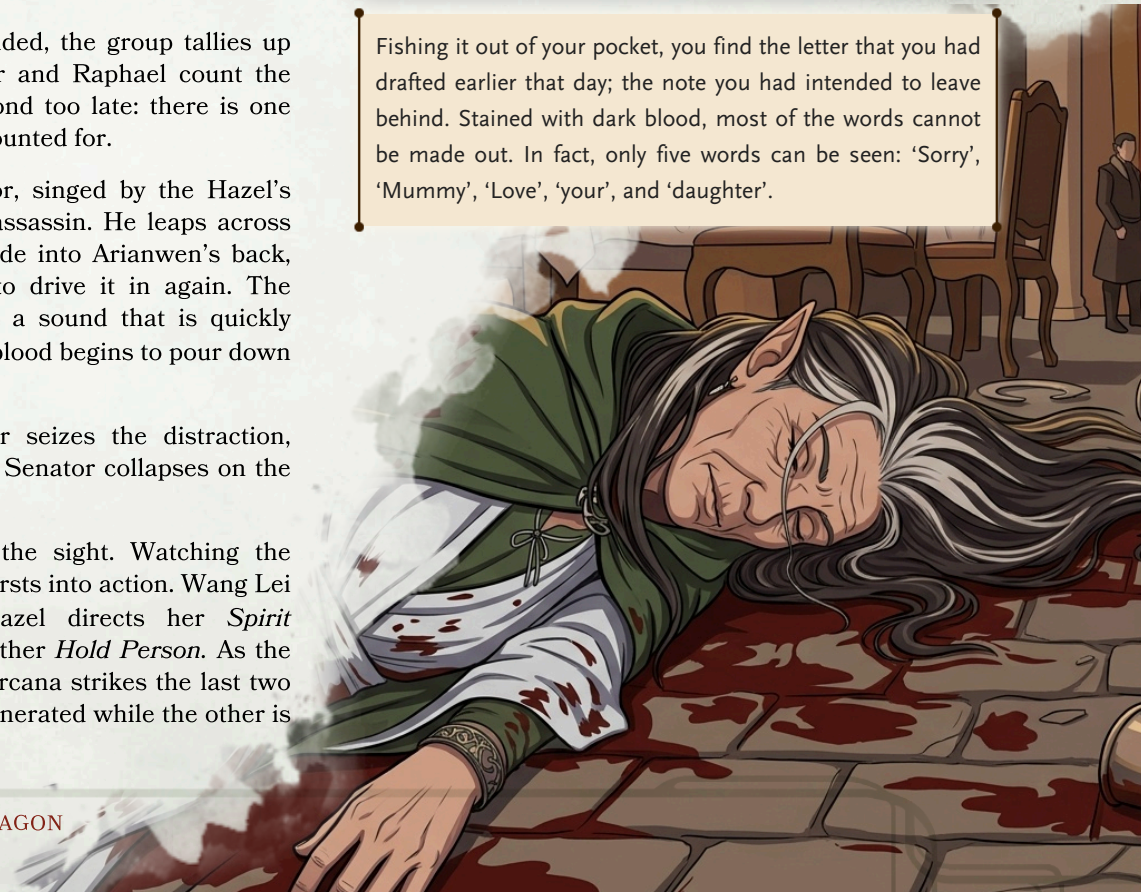
Vilde screams. Sorrow overwhelms the rogue as she struggles to process the fight. *How had it all changed so quickly?* A disgusting cocktail of anger and regret burns in the pit of her stomach as she thinks back to her priorities during the fight. They seem so laughably childish now.

You feel her blood seep into your gown. As it does so, there is a feeling of warmth, but strangely a feeling of something getting wet. It sticks to your body feebly, as if a small amount of force would tear it apart.

"I'm sorry, Vilde," Hazel comes up to the crying elf and rubs her back.

Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) Check
On a successful DC **20** check, Vilde does not tear her letter.

Fishing it out of your pocket, you find the letter that you had drafted earlier that day; the note you had intended to leave behind. Stained with dark blood, most of the words cannot be made out. In fact, only five words can be seen: 'Sorry', 'Mummy', 'Love', 'your', and 'daughter'.



Vilde tucks the letter into her mother's corpse, close to her chest.

"Quickly, quickly!" Angwyn shouts to Melian.



Melian produces, from her robes, a small, 4-inch-tall bone sculpture.

"My lady," she says softly to Vilde. "May I?"

Setting Arianwen flat on the ground, she sets the bone sculpture on the chest of your Mummy. You see blood begin to well up in the eyes of the sculpture, but they do not fall.

"It's something we prepared under her direction," Melian explained. "She knew that death was a possibility, not just for her but for her team, so she had us buy one of these."

Intelligence (Arcana) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Raphael and Hazel can see that magic is pulsing in waves out of the sculpture, replicating the effects of a *Gentle Repose* spell, which not only stops the body from decaying but also extends the time limit of resurrection spells by 10 days.

Hazel asks Melian about the sculpture and its effectiveness at protecting the dead, but the conversation happens a million miles away for Vilde. She barely processes any of it, but the cleric gently reminds the rogue that they should try and get more of these sculptures.

"Did she have any other arrangements in mind?" Vilde asks, wiping her tears away and steeling herself.

"No, m'lady," Melian replies. "She has left most of her belongings in Nike, and just brought the stuff she needed for adventuring."

Vilde can feel Angwyn glaring at her as she continues the conversation. "You should have left," He snapped.

Before Vilde responds, flooding into the room are two dozen knights. Leading the charge is the Inspector Harondus Eisensturm. By his side is a fully armoured Breakbones, Mason, and the rest of the 74th Expedition.

"Secure the crime scene! Nobody leaves until we've taken statements," The Inspector barks. "Arrest the assassin and the lycanthrope."

Following investigation procedures, the Inspector wants to interrogate everybody, and will start with the Party as witnesses. He would not take no for an answer, and will arrest anybody who stands in his way. Wukong, having consumed the assassin he slayed, starts to regain control. As his bloodlust subsides, the simian shifts back to his normal form.

"Wait a minute, Inspector," Breakbones protests. "These are friends of the Camp - "

"We can do this the easy way, or the hard way," the sorcerer threatens the half-orc. "But we need to get in line. You need to get in line. Now, a prominent political figure is assassinated. On your watch. Correct me if I am wrong, but that's the second instance of that happening. You should be lucky that I do not relieve you of your command," he points accusingly at Breakbones. "And given your stark incompetence, you do not get to tell me how to do my job."

The Inspector storms away from Breakbones, turning to Vilde. He bows deeply, saying, "I am sorry for your loss, Lady Amadeus. But I assure you, we will get to the bottom of this."

The sorcerer snaps his fingers, pointing at several Guardsmen to direct them to take statements from Hazel, Raphael and Salazar. Two guards flank Wukong, collecting his *Jingubang* and manacling the paladin.

Strength (Athletics) Check

On a failed DC **20** check, Wukong struggles against the bonds but does not break free from the manacles.

"Inspector," Raphael chimes in. "We captured the assassin. I think it is well within our rights to interrogate him. We take responsibility for what has happened here due to our Party, and I will extract all information that there is to have."

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a **DC 20** check, the Inspector lets an individual from the 52nd join the interrogation. He flat out refuses Vilde for fear of retribution. The rest are free to listen in.

"I fully agree," the Inspector says. "I am happy to let one of you accompany me during the investigation, but in the meantime we will have to take statements. Sir Wang Lei, if you wouldn't mind, I'd like to start with you, and then I will take the Lady Amadeus's statement - "

"Actually, sir, if I may, I will take the Lady Amadeus's statements," Mason volunteers. The Inspector furrows his brows, shooting a look at Mason, then Breakbones, then Vilde. Nevertheless, he nods.

"I'll need to talk to my father first," Vilde says.

"My lady, that is against standard protocol," The Inspector Harondus protests. "Witness testimony must be kept pristine. I'm not saying you will do it, but more often than not, people can collude stories. Also, we don't want an instance of a witness saying they saw something affect another witness's memory of whether or not they saw it for themselves."

"Do you have no heart?" Wukong says as he is marched out. "She just lost her mother - "

"He's right!" Hazel protests.

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a **DC 15** check, the Inspector allows for the conversation.

"No, no, of course," Harondus replies. He turns to Mason and continues, "They can exchange a few words, just nothing about the case. Please just stand nearby and watch."

The squire nods.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check

Hazel, Salazar and Raphael can investigate the bodies while giving their statements.

On a successful DC **15** check, Hazel and Raphael notices a difference amongst the assassins. You see that the assassins are from a myriad of different races. There are elves, humans, half-orcs, and tieflings. Even amongst the humans, there is a mixture of local Kroonstadians and mainlanders.

On a successful DC **20** check, Salazar locks in. He notices a similarity amongst the assassins. Their blades are all the same. You can see a button of some kind in the hilt, and the insignia of a five-headed hydra emblazoned in the blade. Upon closer inspection, the hilt is empty, and can be inserted with vials of acid.

On a successful DC **25** check, Salazar notices the *Potions of Invisibility* - the corks of the glass bottles that was used to hold the Potion had a symbol in the seal - *Gilmore's Curd and Culture*. The wizard consults his mind palace and remembers that that was a shop in Ryoko that Yandala had previously visited with her brother.

The wizard suspects that the insiginia of the five headed hydra is a house sigil, but he cannot recall which house. Given that the bottles were purchased in Ryoko, he believes that they cannot rule out the involvement of House Tokugane as well.

Bringing you to the side, the Inspector takes out a small, rectangular blue crystal. You recognize this as *a Stone of Recording*. He sets it in between both of you as his ring glows and a pulse of familiar magic washes over you. It is a *Zone of Truth* spell.

Do you fail the saving throw, or resist it?

Sensing the paladin's reluctance, the Inspector assures him, "I'm sorry, but this is standard procedure. We need to get to the bottom of this. I assure you, I am only interested in the events that has happened tonight."

Wang Lei nods, submitting himself to the spell.

"Okay," the Inspector says. "Please state your name for the record."

"Lieutenant Wang Lei," the paladin responds.

"And I understand you are the Lieutenant of Summer's Outpost, and a paladin of Prosperity," Wang Lei replies. "Am I right?"

"I... was," the sorcerer replies.

His eyes raise in stark surprise. "Okay, and when did you change your oath?"

"About two weeks ago," He replies. "Shortly after we arrived."

"I don't mean to pry," the Inspector continues. "I understand that changing an oath is a deeply personal choice. But it is imperative for us to understand and establish who you are as context for the statement you are about to give. What are you sworn to, now?"

"Nothing," Wang Lei replies. "It's complicated. Story for another time."

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a contested check, Wang Lei fails to convince the Inspector to drop the matter.

"Alright, okay..." Harondus continues. "And you were, of course, conscripted for the Expedition. Tell us what happened tonight."

"We were having dinner," Wang Lei recalls. "Suddenly, a group of assassins came out to backstab us. There were seven of them, and they were clearly targetting the

members of the 52nd Expedition."

"It has not escaped my notice too, that after the assassins began their attack, the majority of those in the room fled out, to call for guards and gather their own arms and armour. And yet, interestingly, you have yours on. Why were you armoured?"

"It's from experience," Wang Lei replies. "We have been here for two weeks, and this is a particularly dangerous continent. This sort of thing happens almost every day. If we had no armour, more people could have died."

The Inspector nods as he switches off the crystal. He leans in close and whispers, "Do you know what the Guard does to oathbreakers?"

Wang Lei, aware that the penalty of oathbreaking is exile, nods.

"I can keep your secret, Sir Wang Lei, of course," He says. "Or I can excommunicate you, right now, by the power vested in me. Strip you of all your rank. Which do you prefer?"

"It's complicated," Wang Lei offers. "I need to focus on our objective here, first, then I will have some time to work on my oath - "

"That's not what I asked," Harondus replies flatly. "I am asking you, of the two things I can choose to do, what do you want me to do?"

"I'd prefer it if you keep my secret," Wang Lei offers.

"Good, good," He says. "That's what I prefer too. You have been travelling with Raphael Antarra for quite some time, yes? As you know, I'm sure, that the houses in the Chamber of Lords-Advisory are eternally struggling against one another. It is no secret that we vie for supremacy in the dark. Here's the deal - you are going to be my inside man. But first, a gesture of good faith: where does the sorcerer draw his power from?"

Wang Lei keeps quiet as he considers his options. "Some god, I think."

"Which one, in particular?"

"Something ancient and powerful," Wang Lei says. "I don't think it is one of the known gods."

"Interesting. You have given me much to think about tonight," Harondus says. "Now, our deal. "I want you to befriend him. Gain his trust. Heal him in battle. Protect him from monsters. But, more importantly, I want you to make sure he never returns back to the mainland. Do that, and I'd keep your secret. Fail, and I will make sure the Guard knows. Do we have a deal?"

"I'll think about it," Wang Lei tries.

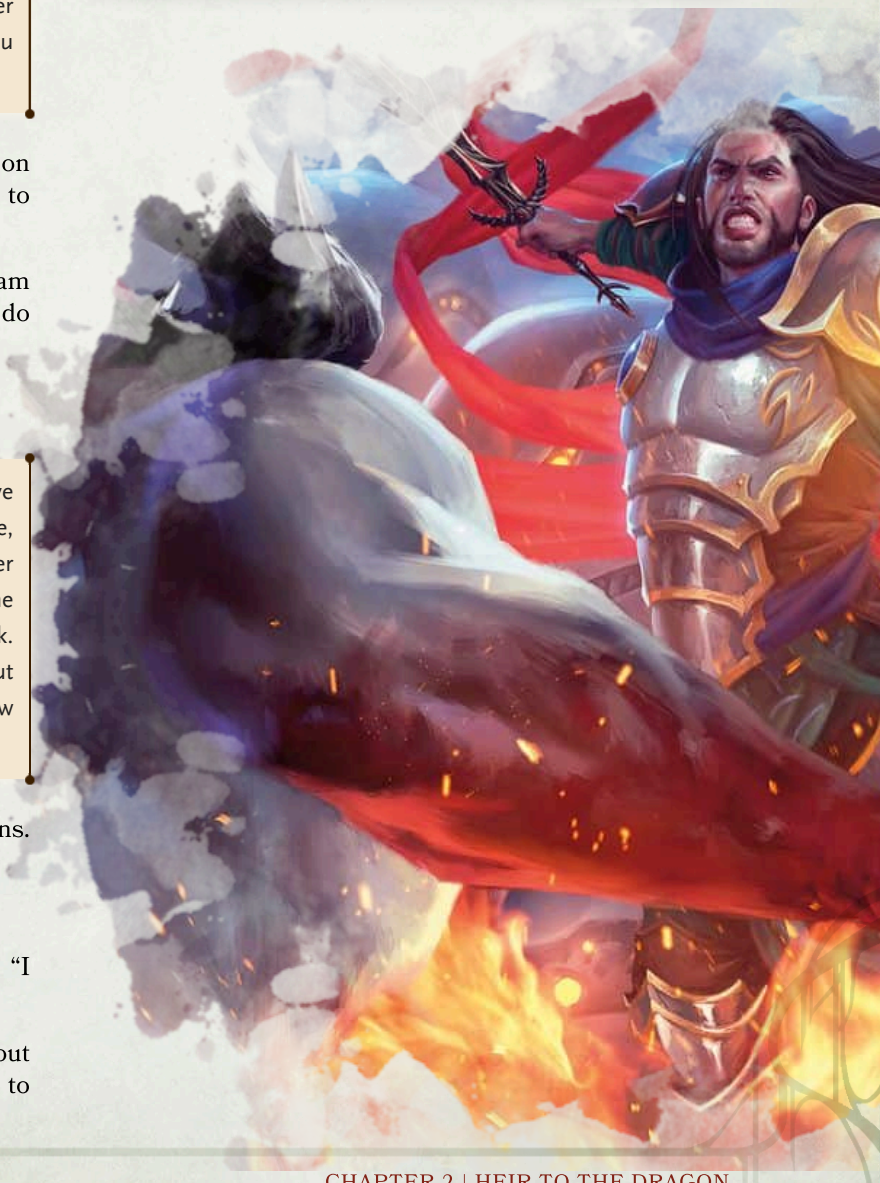
"No," Harondus demands. "An answer, right here, right now. I want you to swear to it."

Taking a New Oath

While Harondus is pressuring Wang Lei to swear to help him and his family, Wang Lei's decision to take on a new divine responsibility is ultimately his. He can choose to:

(1) **Swear fealty to House Eisensturm**. By dedicating himself to serve the noble family governing the town of Donnerfels, he becomes an *Oath of the Crown* paladin.

(2) **Swear to safeguard the mortal realm against Yog-So'Thoth**. By dedicating himself to protect the world from the predations of extraplanar creatures, he becomes an *Oath of the Watchers* paladin.



“Kill him,” Wang Lei hears the Gray Baby’s voice in his mind with incredible urgency. He feels a surge in vitality as he becomes aware of the Child empowering him with the relentless fortitude of the undead. “Kill him! KILL HIM KILL HIM!”

The paladin weighs his options. He understands that oathbreaking is a dark stain on his career that cannot be erased, but recalls that part of the conscription offered by the Empress for the Expedition is an imperial pardon. He surveys the threats in the room, and sees that while the Inspector is probably the only spellcaster in the room, there is an overwhelming amount of knights in the place that would likely attempt to arrest him for striking the Inspector.

“Okay,” Wang Lei replies. “If your concern is Raphael unleashing an elder god, that I can promise you I will stop. But I will not be your puppet.”

A sly smile crawls over the face of the Inspector. “Sure.”

As the rest of the Party continues to give out their statements, Vilde and Mason walk over to Angwyn, who is in the middle of giving his. The pair interject, with Mason asking the Guardsman to give them both some space. He stands respectfully some distance away, but remain in earshot.

“What?” The elf crosses his arms, staring at Vilde.

“As her heir, I think there are some things we need to get in order,” Vilde starts. “Firstly, I’ll be heading to Raya to destroy the Devourer. It is our last hope if we want to bring back Mummy - “

“Was she your mother?” Angwyn asks spitefully. “Isn’t that why you let her die?”

“I didn’t see you do anything,” Vilde snarls. “All I saw was you hiding behind the pillar like a coward.”

“Not anymore,” The elf retorts. “I’ll be going to destroy the Devourer as well. And I do not plan to sleep until I use her bow to fire the arrow that will free her.”

Vilde shoulder checks him, forcing Angwyn to stumble back. “It doesn’t feel like you can do much for this Expedition,” Vilde scoffs. As the volume of the interaction grows, everybody in the room falls silent momentarily to watch the father and daughter fight. “And if I were you, I’d make myself useful. Go back to Nike and get our affairs in order. Obviously there are a lot of political parties against us, and I need you to keep her body safe and also make sure nobody takes over Nike while I am gone. Can you do that?”

“Don’t you think that that’s what I want to do?” Angwyn scrambles to his feet. “But I know that if I leave you alone, you will dilly dally and take your sweet time! What did you spend your entire time in the Camp doing? Shopping in the bazaar! When, I don’t know, you could be checking for threats, or - “

“I was shopping for supplies,” Vilde says exasperatedly. “Don’t you need supplies to be prepared? Also, number one, you’re just a trophy husband. You can’t even fight. You don’t even understand the first rule of fighting - “

“And what is the first rule of fighting?” Angwyn yells back.

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Vilde convinces her stubborn, angry, grieving father that perhaps he is ill-suited at running headlong into danger and dying, but does not succeed on getting him to return to Nike.

Melian comes up as the pair’s fight grow to a crescendo. “Uh, m’lady,” She mutters, trying to calm them down. “If there is a message you intend for Nike, I can send it - “

“Can you please convince this buffoon to do what he needs to do?” Vilde commands. “I think one family member dying is enough. We don’t need two.”

Angwyn sits down on the chair of the dining table, sulking. He wipes his tears off as he buries his face in his hands.

“He is much more suited at organizing things,” Vilde mutters. “And I think that’s in Nike.”

Melian’s voice drops to a whisper. “I can’t order him to do anything, m’lady. He’s my boss - “

“He’s not your boss,” Vilde snaps. “I’m your boss.”

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Vilde convinces Melian to bring her home.

Mason steps forward as the argument comes to a head. “M’lady, is everything alright?”

Vilde shoots a last look at Melian before turning to Mason. “Yes, I just have to get everything in order. As a leader, I gotta do what I gotta do. There’s no time to grief.”

The squire nods and brings Vilde to a corner in the room. He pulls you into a big hug as he kisses your forehead. “M’lady, I am so sorry for your loss,” He whispers. “I should have been here to help. How are you feeling?”

“No, it’s fine,” Vilde replies. “There’s no way you could have known that would happen. What I feel is that I need to step up, now. We need to be mission focused.”

As you say that, a memory of your past begins to surge to the forefront of your mind. You remember the night your mother offered you a choice, almost seventy years ago.

As you lay there, sickened and numb with pain, you watch your Mummy enter the room. She sits by your bedside as she brushes your hair out of your face, gently stirring you awake.

"Vilde? Darling?" She asks.

Coughing, the rogue replies in a croaking voice, "Yes?"

"Honey, I- I may have something that can help," Arianwen says softly. She sets a small, yellow vial of liquid on Vilde's bedside table. "This right here, it's an elixir cultivated by the monks at the Monastery of the Yellow Rose. It may be able to cure your engorged heart, and give you a normal life. But, it works by fundamentally altering your body. It has an equally likely chance of mutating you. Turn you into a monstrosity."

The Senator pauses, as if steeling herself to continue.

"I'm telling you this because I want you to choose. As much as I want to make you drink it, this is something that I think you must choose to do, and that I cannot choose for you." The Senator's voice breaks as she loses control of her anxiety. "Risky choices like this, they not only define our lives, but have a ripple effect and affect the lives of those around us. Every choice you ever make, no matter how insignificant it may seem, matters because the pebbles we throw into the pond will become somebody else's tsunami."

A pang of sharp guilt pierces Vilde's sides as she recalls her mother's last moments. She remembers her own, burning priority to hide the scimitars from her mother, instead of making sure that her Mummy was safe.

"We will do whatever it takes to get her back," Mason says, breaking Vilde's reverie. "I promise. Listen, I've already prepared our supplies. Duo, Princess and Khan are all loaded up. Out on the road, we would have a month's worth of food and water. Say the word, and we can race towards Raya."

"We'll set off tomorrow morning," She nods. "We need to interrogate the assassin, and I think we can all do with some rest." Her voice drops to a whisper, as she fills him in on the intention to free the 51st Expedition. "Just get the animals ready at the start of the gate."

Mason nods as he produces his parchment and starts taking down her statement.

Complicated Questions

Wukong. You and the assassin are escorted into the prison cell by the Knight Gaya Seremai, Firebeard, Goldenguard and a guy you guys know as Gaston. Manacled and flanked by guards on both sides, they march the two of you into the cells.

Firebeard and Gaston heads off to put the assassin in another room as Gaya and Goldenguard deposit you in your cell. Securing you against the wall, Goldenguard orders you to strip. He collects your armour, and having carried your weapon down here as well, the dwarf says in a gravelly low voice, "I'm going to put all this into the duty room."

"Wait a minute," Gaya says. "Let me just pat him down to make sure he doesn't have anything on him."

"Hey! Watch where your hands are going!" Wukong protests.

Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) Check

On a contested check against Goldenguard's perception, Gaya successfully slips Wukong a *Thieves' Tools.*

The knight slips a set of *Thieves' Tools* to Wukong, who collects it with his tail. Gaya whispers quickly, "You have an hour. After that, I will have to sound the alarm. If not they'll think that I'm a traitor."

Wukong nods, watching the pair leave. Quietly, Wukong undoes his manacles. He creeps out silently, just as Firebeard and Gaston complete depositing the assassin.

"What?!" Gaston says, stunned at the free simian. "How are you free?"

Wukong winks at the guard. Gaston tries to arrest him again.

"Wait, wait, wait!" Wukong protests. "I need your help. I'm trying to save everyone. Please, stay in the room, and be manacled. I'll disguise you as me."

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a successful DC **20** check, Wukong convinces Gaston and Firebeard to help.

"Okay, do you want to beat me up?" Gaston asks.

"What? No! I'll just disguise you." Wukong instinctively reaches for his *Ring of 72 Transformation,* but realizes the Guard has it.

"Okay, wait a minute," Wukong curses. "I'll be back."

Dexterity (Stealth) Check

On a successful contested check, Wukong quietly sneaks up behind Goldenguard as the dwarf puts away his belongings.

Retrieving all of his items, he also finds all of the evidence collected from the assassination. He pockets the 4 *Potions of Invisibility,* drinking one and using his newfound invisibility to don his armour. He stalks back to his jail cell, chaining Gastion in his place and using the *Ring of 72 Transformation* to cast *Disguise Self.*

Passing by the cells of the 51st Expedition, Wukong wonders if he should free them. Afraid that the illusory spell will not hold up to inspection, Wukong heads out of the jail. He heads up to the inner bailey, hoping to find his friends.

By sheer luck, he runs into the rest of his Party. Done with giving their statements, the Inspector Eisensturm, Breakbones, Angwyn, and the majority of the 52nd Expedition make their way to the assassin. The sorcerer dips out to retrieve his *Nekronomicon* before the interrogation. Angwyn does the same, retrieving the Senator's longbow.

Wukong, still invisible, comes up alongside. He pulls Hazel abruptly, prompting her to squeal in surprise.

Dexterity (Stealth) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Harondus does not notice Hazel's surprise.

The pair stays behind as the Party pulls ahead, making their way to the jail.

"It's Wukong," the simian whispers. "We need to prepare. I don't think we can stay here for long." He explains what has happened with him, and that he stole the *Potions of Invisibility* used by the assassins.

"Okay, let's go back," Hazel says. "We can just quickly pack all our stuff. Once we're done, maybe you should slip out first with all of our gear, before your Invisibility fades."

The rabbitfolk and simian head back and prepare all of the Party's equipment. They load it onto Duo, Princess and Khan, and use the rest of the *Potions of Invisibility* to make the beasts invisible and transport the equipment out.

Entering the jail, the Inspector leads all of you down into the assassin's cell. Accompanying all of you is Breakbones and Angwyn.

The Inspector casts *Minor Illusion* on the bars, turning them into a plane of one-sided glass. Seeing it, Raphael casts *Rary's Telepathic Bond,* facilitating the Party's communication.

"Maybe you should go back," Vilde says dismissively to her father. "I'm not sure your stomach can handle this."

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a failed DC **15** check, Angwyn chooses to stay.

"Don't tell me what to do, young lady," Angwyn spat. "Don't forget, you're not even her real daughter."

Vilde shoves her father, causing him to fall prone. She tries to block him with her body, but the elf stays.

Raphael and Harondus enters the cell. In it, is a human male with a mohawk and a crazed smile.



As Harondus asks opening questions, Wang Lei speaks to those telepathically bonded, "I don't think we can leave the Inspector alive. He cannot leave this place. We should end him the moment he is done with the assassin. Then, we can break the 51st Expedition out, and pin it on Kaelen's half - "

"We can't kill the Inspector," Breakbones complains. "How many people do you want to die in this Camp?! Besides, Brother Aldric is unaccounted for. He isn't going to corroborate our story - "

"Look, your career is screwed," Wang Lei points out. "The best choice is to kick the can down the road - "

"If we want to pin Lyara Porter's death on the 51st Expedition, we need to get the Inspector on our side," Breakbones replies. "It's better if we convince him that the 51st did it. If not, it's going to be a long, and evergrowing, list of people who have died here, in the Camp, while we are here. We have to get him on our side!"

"We can threaten him also," Salazar offers. "Find something to blackmail him."

"Harondus has something against Raphael," Wang Lei explains.

"Raphael," Salazar replies. "Do you have any dirt on the Inspector?"

A smell of petrichor floods the room as everyone feels their hairs stand on end. As the Inspector casts *Detect Thoughts* against the assassin, static emanates from the sorcerer. Salazar, Wang Lei, Vilde, Angwyn and Breakbones all feel the *Detect Thoughts* spell pass over their minds as well. The Party quashes any thoughts of murder at the last second.

"Who sent you?" Harondus demands.

The assassin remains silent with a crazed smile. The Inspector's eyes glow silvery-blue as he probes the mind of the man in front of him.

Raphael drops onto his heels, squatting to the man's eyeline. "I see you," the sorcerer whispers. The low, melodic cadence of the *Fear* spell vibrates in the hollows of Shago's teeth. He tries to jerk away, but his limbs have turned to wet lead, pinned in place by an invisible, suffocating weight. Raphael's jaw unhinges, past the point of natural length and defies the anatomy of any mortal man. Deep within the dark cavern of his throat, a single, unblinking eye ignites. It flares with a violent, metastatic purple.

In that blinding flash of psychic agony, the sorcerer rips the assassin's name bleeding from his mind: Shago.

The man screams. His eyes rolling back as the terror takes root, as a puddle of forms involuntarily under him.

"Uh, what did you do that for?" Harondus asks, shocked.

"He wasn't cooperative," Raphael points out.

"I'm in his mind," the Inspector replies. "I'm listening to everything - "

"I don't think he's going to tell you," Raphael replies. "Your methods of interrogation are too soft." The sorcerers turn back to the assassin, who is now prostrate on the ground in his own filth. He is catatonic, paralyzed completely by the *Fear* spell.

Outside, Salazar taps Vilde. "I think there's something you should know. Back at the dining room, I was studying the scene." The wizard shares all that he has learnt from his investigation, including the sigil of the five-headed hydra.

Intelligence (History) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Vilde recalls that the Cer'Dorei Republic - the elven nation - has three major urban population centres: Nike, Syllamere and Forum Triciti. Vilde remembers the Alarion Family, the ruling party of Syllamere, as having been frequently associated with hydra imagery.

Vilde shares her suspicions with the Party telepathically, pointing out that they may have had political desires to stop her run for Prime Minister.

"Let's try this again," Raphael says. His eyes glow purple as he casts *Suggestion*. "Tell me everything you know about the person who sent you. Describe it to the best of your ability."

"He's bald! He's a gnome! He has a tuft of hair and a white beard!" Shago breaks down completely. "Orvex! Orvex Ocrammas! He put a job up on a board at one of the taverns - "

Raphael probes deeper into the assassin's mind, hoping to pull an image. He extracts a memory of Orvex gathering the assassins in an alley in Malar's Throat, handing out the customized blades and potions for the job.

> As he is handing out the various daggers, potions, and cloaks, you see Orvex say, "Alright, only those who survive get the gold. It's a pot of gold, so the less of you return, the more each one of you gets. If you die, you get nothing. Once done, come back here. I will be here, and I will personally hand out the gold."

"Well, that's a dead end," Harondus says, talking to Raphael. "I don't think he knows anything more. The key person we need to talk to seems to be this Orvex fellow."

"I think your ability as an Inspector is really lacking," Raphael says, realizing that Harondus probably did not probe deeper into Shago's mind. "I will be writing letters back."

"Let's just hang him and call it a day," Harondus shrugs. "He's just a chump, he's useless."



Raphael's thoughts surge in strength, overwhelming Harondus with all his feelings about how uselesss the Eisensturm sorcerer is.

"Okay," The Inspector replies verbally. "That's very hurtful."

Raphael scoffs as he storms out the room. "Useless people doing important shit," the Antarra sorcerer complains as he walks out.

"Waterboard him," Vilde tells Raphael.

"Okay, I think it is gratuitous at this point," Raphael points out. The Party discusses telepathically who is to blame, with Vilde suspecting that it was a joint effort.

With the *Detect Thoughts* faded, Wang Lei reignites the conversation about killing the Inspector.

"I'm not going to do it," Breakbones seethes. "And if you do it, then I guess I've got to arrest you."

The Party weighs their options as Harondus exits, dropping the *Minor Illusion* glass wall. He bows to Vilde. "My lady," the Inspector starts. "I hope you are satisfied with the things we have learnt," Harondus shoots a look to Raphael as he says that. "He's a commoner, so I think we can expedite the situation and just hang him right now. Our next step is of course to identify this Orvex character, somewhere in the Port M'Kaze, but without knowing how he looks like, it might take a while."

"Keep us updated, please," Vilde replies.

"Of course, my lady," Harondus produces a small, rectangular, black crystal, which the Party recognizes is an upgraded version of a *Sending Stone*. "I think what would be wise is if we let the Empire know, have them send a second Inspector to come and look into the matter. After all, I am here to look into a different case - "

"Lyara Porter?" Vilde says curtly. "Let's delay it. You saw what happened, and you were at the dinner. I think you should take charge of this investigation instead. This is more important."

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a successful DC **25** check, Vilde convinces the Inspector to focus on her mother's assassination.

"My lady, if that's what you think is wise, then so be it," the Inspector continues. "If you recall, I did mention that I wanted to take your statements regarding Lyara Porter before all of you leave. I recognize that this should obviously be my priority now, but if it is alright perhaps you can write your statements on a parchment and hand it over to me."

"Yeah, we'll do that," Vilde says. "Within the next five working days."

The Inspector Harondus Eisensturm leaves as the fatigue of the long night takes hold. The Party debates quickly about what they should do for the Inspector as well as the 51st Expedition. As the Party devolves into argument, Salazar breaks away from the group, producing Gwynne's mask. He casts *Knock* on the Shago's jail cell.

"What are you doing?!" Angwyn, who had been intently staring quietly at Arianwen's murderer, is taken aback. His shouts draw Vilde's attention, who joins the trio.

Salazar crosses the distance and slaps the mask on Shago's face. The white eyes glow with brilliant light as the lenses around the googles whir to life. Shago's body, seized by the mask, gasps in surprise.

"Woah!" Gwynne replies. "Salazar!"

"First of all," the wizard begins. "What are you?"

“What do you think I am?” She asks coyly.

“Like a spirit of some sort,” Salazar replies.

Gwynne nods. “You’d be half right.”

“What’s your purpose?” Salazar questioned. “Why are you taking over the bodies of those who wear the mask?”

“We...” She begins. “They made six of us.”

“Who’s they?”

“The enemies of Lolth,” Gwynne begins. “They made us to kill her.”

“And where are the other five?”

Gwynne cocks her head. “You’re trying to find my siblings? Am I not enough for you?”

“Mmmm, this kind of thing,” Salazar says. “The more the better.”

“You’re a greedy little man, aren’t you?” Gwynne whispers. “Why don’t you free me, and I will show you how happy I can make you?”

“And how do I free you?” Salazar asks.

“You unlock my manacles,” Gwynne says matter-of-factly.

“Team,” Salazar snaps his fingers to Vilde’s annoyance. “Yo, guys!”

As he does so, the Party hears Hazel’s voice through a *Sending* stone. “SOS, SOS! Wukong escaped. Guards finding him soon. We need to leave. Meet outside east gate. SOS! SOS! SOS!”

“Okay, we need to get on that,” Vilde says.

“Well, yes,” Salazar begins. “But anyway, this mask. Apparently, there’s not just one, not two, not three, not four, not five - “

“Get to the point,” Vilde rolls her eyes.

“There are six of them,” Salazar continues. “Made to kill Lolth. Unfortunately, I know precious little about this goddesss. Do you know anything about it?”

“No, I don’t,” Vilde says quickly. “But I don’t think we have time for side quests at the moment. We should be focused on destroying the Devourer - “

“I would love to help with the Devourer,” Gwynne says.

“Well, I’m not sure we can trust you,” Vilde says flatly. “What makes us think you are trustworthy?”

“You’re wearing my gauntlets, aren’t you?” Gwynne inspects the *Spider’s Gauntlets*. “Listen, my problem with Lolth is a matter for a different day. If we do not stop Acererak and the Devourer, none of this matters.”

Salazar and Vilde both try to read Gwynne’s intentions, but are unable to do so.

“What do you know about Acererak? Or memories?”

“He’s a lich,” Gwynne explains. “He means harm on the mortal beings of this world. He obviously should be stopped. I don’t know anything about memories, though.”

“Do you know where his phylacteries are?” Salazar asks. “Or how many are there?”

“No,” Gwynne replies. “But I do know that he has one that is alive.”

“Tell us the truth, or I’ll remove the mask,” Salazar threatens.

“You can do that,” She says, her voice just barely a whisper. “And you can keep me in the *Bag of Holding* for the rest of your life. But then you will never know love. Is that what you want?”

“What do you know about me?”

“I can hear everything that has been going on,” Gwynne says. “And here’s my take. I think that the people around you do not care about you at all. I think that they think that they are better than you, and I think I am your only friend.”

Vilde raises an eyebrow. “Are you going to get tricked by this mask?”

“Nah,” Salazar says. “Good try.” He closes the distance and pulls the mask off Shago.

“What was that?” Shago exclaims, shocked. “There was a theater - “

“How’d you like that?” Salazar asks.

“That was crazy,” Shago says. “It was cold, and dark, and - “

Vilde slaps the mask on Shago once more, bringing Gwynne back.

“How’d *you* like that?” The rogue asks.

“Tell us the truth,” Salazar demands.

“What do you think happens when you take the mask off?” Gwynne asks.

“Let’s find out,” Salazar rips the mask off Shago again.

In Taylor Swyft’s cell, Wang Lei and Raphael discuss on the other side of the bars. Taylor Swyft stares quizzically at both of them as the pair begins talking to her.

"Can you nod?" Raphael asks.

Taylor nods.

"We're going to break you out," Raphael says. "There will be an alarm that will ring. But we have a few terms."

The bard nods, encouraging the sorcerer to state his terms.

"We bear you no ill will," Raphael continues. "We hate Kaelen as much as you, and our goal is united in the destruction of the Devourer. We have four conditions: number one, Ariadne comes with us."

The bard vehemently shakes her head.

"Number two, we will return you Gwynne," Raphael says. "However, she will not be on Portia. There's an assassin in the next cell that might serve as a good body. You, Eren and Gwynne can break free. We will try as much as possible to cover your escape. If luck would have it, we will meet each other again in Raya."

She shrugs as Salazar rejoins Raphael and Wang Lei.

"I overheard a little of your conversation with my friend," Salazar says.

"She can only nod or shake her head, by the way," Wang Lei says.

"Oh, okay," Salazar replies. "What do you know about - "

"Wa," Wang Lei replies. "It's only 'Yes' or 'No' questions!"

"Okay, okay," Salazar replies. "Do you know where are the rest of the masks?"

Taylor shakes her head.

"Is this mask related to any liches? Or the Devourer?"

Once more, Taylor shakes her head.

"What do you know about the mask - "

"Okay, that's enough," Wang Lei pulls Salazar away from the bard, knowing that he cannot stop himself.

"Wait, wait!" Salazar protests. "Last question! Am I good looking?"

Taylor nods as the paladin pulls the spiralling wizard away.

Sprezzatura

Having concluded your conversation with Gwynne, Vilde and Salazar head back to rejoin Raphael and Wang Lei.

As you step forward, Vilde, your father Angwyn gently grabs your arm, pulling you back.

He pulls the longbow off his back as he leans against the cold, dungeon stone. "You were right. I'm nothing more than a trophy husband. I don't think I can go on this journey." He stares at you, as if weighing you up. "When you find the Devourer, will you promise me to destroy it with this bow?"

Vilde considers the bow, inspecting it. The gorgeous longbow, made of everbark from the Feywild, flexes and shifts like a living entity.

"She called it Sprezzatura," Angwyn explains.



"Sprezzatura?" Vilde asks.

"Sprezzatura," Angwyn smiles. "It's Elvish. It's... a concept, I guess. For effortless grace. It is the art of making something difficult look completely effortless, which, I'm sure you know, is a philosophy she lived her life by."

"I do not have the strength or constitution for the journey you are about to take," Angwyn says. He spins the bow around in his hand, such that the string faces Vilde. "I will die on this journey. But you won't. You are our last hope."

Vilde stretches her hand out for a dap, which is an Elvish act of comfort. Angwyn daps her up as well.

"I promise you," Vilde says, accepting the longbow. "I will destroy the Devourer with the bow. And, in turn, will you promise me you will do what I asked?"

Angwyn laughs. “I’m giving you the most powerful magic item in my possession, what do you think?”

Two, gleaming, dragon wings of golden light explode from Vilde’s back as she levitates upwards. “Well, technically, this is the most powerful,” the elf laughs as she lands.

“Well, technically, those scimitars aren’t mine,” Angwyn says. “They were your mother’s.”

“I will do her proud, Daddy,” Vilde says. “I will continue her legacy and revive her.”

“We will stand ready,” Angwyn says. “If you let us know once the Devourer is destroyed, we can revive her immediately.”

She nods, passing him a Sending stone.

“And what should I do in the meantime?” Angwyn sighs. “I’m useless.”

“No, no,” Vilde says. “What you lack for in martial strength, you can make up for in charisma. You must make sure the people of Nike follow us, still. That’s of paramount importance. Keep her death a secret, as much as you can.”

“I will try my best,” Angwyn says, hanging his head.

Vilde seizes both of his shoulders, shaking the aged elf. “Do it for our family.”

“Okay, okay, I will!” Angwyn exclaims as he pulls his daughter into a hug. Vilde hugs him back as tears fall freely. “Thank you, Vilde. For giving me hope.” As they break apart, Angwyn dries his eyes and watch as Wang Lei begins dragging Salazar away.

“Are you going to free your sister?” He asks, looking at Ariadne.

“I’ve spoken to her, and I believe she has no ill-will against us,” Vilde explains.

“Why will she have ill-will against me?”

“Okay, what do you mean?” Vilde says, rolling her eyes. “You cheated on both of our mums.”

His voice drops to a whisper. “She doesn’t know that, does she?”

“Okay, regardless,” Vilde replies. “I won’t tell her, but I need you to focus up. Let’s keep our family safe.”

He nods. “I’m going back to the Port, and we will head back to Nike.”

“I love you, you know,” Angwyn says. “I love your mum, more, but obviously I love you too - “

Vilde rolls her eyes at her idiotic father, but stops him as he begins to walk away. “Wait, Dad,” the elf replies. “I love you too.”

Prison Break

As the long night draws to a close, the Party remain committed on trying to free the 51st Expedition. Salazar, Wang Lei, Raphael and Vilde reconvenes in their rooms with Hazel to formulate a plan. Having been informed by Wukong previously about the Knight Gaya’s plan to sound the alarm, Wang Lei quickly finds the knight and tells him to hold out first while the Party makes a plan.

After prolonged discussion, Vilde and Raphael convinces Salazar to leave Gwynne behind. He agrees. After the Party finalizes their plan for the prison break, they break up and rest up from the long night.

As the Party retires to their room, Salazar does not. The wizard slips back into Shago’s jail cell.

“Something’s been bugging me,” Salazar puts Gwynne’s mask on Shago once again, this time alone. “Your... siblings. They are focused on killing Lolth, yes? They do not care about Acererak, or the Devourer.”

“Yes,” Gwynne replies. “They are not concerned with the Graying at all. They care about one thing and one thing only, achieving their sole purpose in life.”

“And yet, you are,” Salazar points out. “Why do you care about Acererak and the Devourer? What made you change your mind?”

“Somebody convinced me,” Gwynne says.

“Is it somebody you love?” Salazar asks.

Quietly, Gwynne nods.

“Is that person Taylor Swyft?”

Silence hangs in the air. Gwynne does not respond. Salazar regards the figure still chained to the wall, soiled in Shago’s filth. “Are you going to ask me more stupid questions, or take me out on a date?”

“Just a couple more stupid questions,” the wizard cannot help but smile. “Do you know how to detect phylacteries?”

“I don’t know how to detect it, but I know what can,” Gwynne replies. “It was a book available at the House of the All-Seeing Orb, but it was loaned out from the library. The *Nekronomicon*.”

“Anything else we should know?” Salazar stands up, rising to his full height and getting ready to leave.

“He’s not alone,” Gwynne replies. “Acererak is using the Devourer to rear an atropal - a dead baby god.”

“You good,” Salazar says. The wizard leaves the mask back on Shago.

Having been notified by Hazel that Wukong has left the Camp with all of their belongings, Raphael improvises.

Thaisha shapeshifts to a falcon, taking flight into the night over the dark jungle. The druid finds the paladin, taking over protection of the Party's equipment and directs him to sneak back into the Camp. Wukong shapeshifts using his *Ring of 72 Transformation* into Thaisha, sauntering back into Camp Vengeance.

At the break of dawn, Mason, Vilde, Wang Lei, Hazel head out of Camp. On their way out, Vilde leaves 100 platinum pieces behind for Melian, directing her to go buy another *Grave Tender* bone sculpture. The rogue and the squire also sneak around the bazaar, hoping to be able to find another sculpture, but to no avail.

"Alright, whatever," Vilde curses. "Head out there and rendezvous with the rest, Mason."

The elf stealthily sneaks back into the jail and unlocks Taylor's jail cell. Undoing the leather muzzle, Vilde pours a swig of tej into the bard's mouth, and directs her to cast *Suggestion* on the guard to open the gate. "We'll cause a distraction for you," She explains.

The bard nods, swirling the honey liquor in her mouth. Having achieved an accord, Vilde slips out of her cell, and head towards Ariadne's.

The rogue sneakily breaks into her half-sister's cell. "Okay, we don't have much time," Vilde whispers. "We've got to go."

"Thank you, Vilde," Ariadne says. "Should we free the rest?"

"I've done that already," the rogue lies. "We will be going on our Expedition. Taylor says they will go their separate ways because she doesn't want to join us. Okay, let's go!"

Charisma (Deception) Check
On a successful DC **25** check, Ariadne believes her half-sister.

"Okay, yeah," Ariadne rises to her feet. Did you manage to grab all my stuff?"

"Yes, yes, let's go!" Vilde presses. The pair sneaks out, meeting Salazar, Wukong (disguised as Thaisha) and Raphael. Wukong uses the *Ring of 72 Transformation,* shifting her to take Mason's form.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check
On a failed DC **16** check, the guards on patrol does not realize that Ariadne has broken free and is not Mason.

With Wukong and Salazar's help, Raphael shapeshifts to an invisible Kaelen. The trio put their plan into action.

Out by the shrine of the Candescent Church, an exhausted Breakbones takes a small break. She rips off her armour as she contemplates lighting up a cigarette, the first one in years.

"Fuck it," She thinks to herself. She wonders if this day, the toughest one in her career thus far, was to be the beginning of the end of her career. "If I don't smoke on a day like this, when can I?"

The exhausted knight picks up the tobacco and starts rolling it in her hands, eager for one last moment of peace before the shitty days of endless questions about her competence.

Locking in, Raphael sculpts his *Fireball.* He twists and turns, moulding the spell to look like a roiling, writhing mass of dragons.

"No," She whispers to herself. "If I can survive working with that bitch Lyara Porter, I can survive anything." She finishes rolling her cigarette, hope and determination swelling in her chest.

She snaps her finger, intending to cast *Produce Flame.*

As she does so, to her complete and utter surprise, Raphael unleashes hellfire. A torrent of fire explodes the wall of the Inner Bailey. Salazar casts *Invisibility* on the sorcerer and himself amidst the chaos as the trio flees.

"What the fuck - "

Charisma (Performance) Check
For anyone to see through the ruse, the guards will need to roll beat a DC **15** check.